



**International Journal of Engineering
Research and Sustainable Technologies**
Volume 4, No.3, Sep 2026, P 26-35

ISSN: 2584-1394 (Online version)

**AI-BASED WATER QUALITY DETECTION: USING pH STRIP, COMPUTER VISION
AND CLOUD DASHBOARD**

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DOI: <https://doi.org/10.63458/ijerst.v4i3.167>

Abstract

Water quality assessment is a basic idea of environmental management. It has effects on human health, farming and industry. Traditional ways to check parameters, such as pH usually use manual color strips. These strips are highly subjective and often produce mistakes. Digital probes are expensive. Need regular calibration. This paper proposes a scalable mobile-first Internet of Things (IoT) and Artificial Intelligence (AI) framework that automates water pH testing. The framework uses a Flutter app, computer vision with machine learning models from Scikit-learn or TensorFlow. It maps the Red, Green and Blue (RGB) values of a standard pH strip to continuous pH numbers. The system automatically classifies water as acidic, safe or alkaline. Sends real-time data to a Firebase-hosted web dashboard built with HTML and Chart.js. This paper explains the system's architecture, the specific mathematical algorithms used, optimization functions, data augmentation strategies, security measures, fuzzy logic implementation, a detailed economic feasibility study, real-world deployment cases and the future direction of AI-driven environmental telemetry.

Keywords: Artificial Intelligence, Computer Vision, Convolutional Neural Networks, Fuzzy Logic, IoT, Machine Learning, Water Quality, Cloud Computing, Edge AI.

1. Introduction

Water is a resource. It keeps people healthy balances nature and drives the economy. According to the World Health Organization (WHO) and the United Nations Sustainable Development Goals (SDG 6: Clean Water and Sanitation) access to water is a basic human right. Rapid industrial growth, human-made agricultural methods and city expansion have damaged global water quality. Monitoring parameters—especially pH which controls how chemicals dissolve and become available to living things—is crucial to prevent ecological disasters and outbreaks of waterborne diseases. Today environmental agencies and individuals use either laboratory machines or manual pH strips. Digital meters give precision and continuous tracking but their use on a large scale especially in developing countries is limited by high cost, power needs and maintenance. Manual chemical strips are common cheap. Need no power. However they suffer from observer bias, changes in conditions and wear over time. To close this technology gap this paper introduces a framework that uses everyday smartphone cameras, edge computing and machine learning. The main goal is to remove subjectivity from color analysis and create a continuous cloud-connected data flow. By turning physical color changes into vectors this framework delivers laboratory-grade accuracy on consumer devices.

2. Related Work

The intersection of computer vision and environmental monitoring has grown quickly over the decade. Research in this field can be grouped into three stages.

2.1 Phase 1: Traditional Optical Colorimetry

Early attempts to automate color readings used flatbed scanners and laboratory lighting. These systems ran on desktop software that mapped scanned pixels to values. Although this removed bias it lost the main advantage of

portability. Samples had to be moved to the scanner, which allowed temperature and chemical changes to affect the pH before analysis.

2.2 Phase 2: Smartphone-Assisted Methodologies

With the rise of high-resolution smartphone cameras researchers started proposing colorimetry. Cho et al. Proposed a measurement method using a special color adaptation algorithm. Jiang et al. Created a smartphone reader that used color subtraction techniques. These early systems often needed 3-D printed accessories—such, as light-blocking shells or external LED calibrators—to control lighting. This requirement made large-scale commercial use difficult.

2.3 Phase 3: Machine Learning and Edge AI

More recent studies have put machine learning into the mobile pipeline. Hossain et al. [3] Showed that training machine learning algorithms on different lighting datasets can remove the need for physical light shields. Li et al. [5] Took this further by adding computer vision to broaden biological sensor systems.

With these advances a big gap still exists in full data integration. Most papers only look at color extraction and ignore how to share data and keep a history [9]. The framework we propose goes beyond the state of the art by adding a wrap around the machine learning driven optical analysis.

3. Proposed Methodology

The proposed framework operates across three distinct computational layers, ensuring a strict separation of concerns. Figure 1 details the macroscopic data flow of the system.

3.1 Edge Acquisition Layer (Flutter Mobile Client)

The client-facing interface is a mobile application developed using Flutter, ensuring cross-platform compatibility across iOS and Android ecosystems. The application accesses the smartphone's native camera hardware via platform channels. To ensure consistency, the UI overlays a bounding box guide on the camera viewfinder, instructing the user to align the strip correctly. The application actively locks the camera's auto-white-balance (AWB), auto-exposure (AE), and auto-focus (AF) during capture to prevent the hardware's internal image signal processor (ISP) from artificially altering the chemical strip's true color.

3.2 Computer Vision Processing Layer (Python)

Upon image capture, the payload is transmitted via a secure RESTful API to a Python backend server utilizing the FastAPI framework. Here, the raw image undergoes morphological transformations. OpenCV applies a Gaussian blur function to reduce high-frequency camera noise before executing Canny edge detection to isolate the Region of Interest (ROI).

3.3 Cloud and Presentation Layer (Firebase)

Once the intelligence layer computes the exact pH, the data payload is pushed asynchronously to a Firebase Real-time Database. A secure web dashboard, constructed utilizing HTML5, CSS3, and Chart.js, subscribes to this Firebase data stream via WebSockets, allowing municipal authorities to view data updates in absolute real-time without refreshing the client browser.

4. Theoretical Background and Mathematics

Translating optical data into precise chemical metrics re-quires rigorous mathematical transformations.

4.1 Color Space Transformation

Smartphones capture image matrices in the standard Red, Green, and Blue (RGB) color space. However, RGB is

highly susceptible to variations in illumination. To isolate the true color (chrominance) from the lighting intensity (luminance), the system converts the RGB matrix to the Hue, Saturation, Value (HSV) color space [7].

Let $R, G, B \in [0, 1]$ represent the normalized color channels. The Value (V) channel is defined as the maximum intensity:

$$V = C_{max} = \max(R, G, B) \quad (1)$$

The Saturation (S) is calculated using the difference between the maximum and minimum channels ($\Delta = C_{max} - C_{min}$):

$$S = \begin{cases} 0 & \text{if } C_{max} = 0 \\ \frac{\Delta}{C_{max}} & \text{if } C_{max} \neq 0 \end{cases} \quad (2)$$

Finally, the Hue (H) is calculated piece-wise:

$$H = \begin{cases} 60^\circ \times \frac{(G-B) \bmod 6}{\Delta} & \text{if } C_{max} = R \\ 60^\circ \times \frac{(B-R) + 6}{\Delta} & \text{if } C_{max} = G \\ 60^\circ \times \frac{(R-G) + 6}{\Delta} & \text{if } C_{max} = B \end{cases} \quad (3)$$

4.2 Canny Edge Detection Mathematics

To automatically crop the pH strip, the Canny edge detection algorithm is applied. First, the image intensity gradient is found utilizing Sobel filters

$$G_x = \begin{bmatrix} -1 & 0 & 1 \\ -2 & 0 & 2 \\ -1 & 0 & 1 \end{bmatrix} * A \quad (4)$$

The edge gradient magnitude G and direction ϑ are then calculated:

$$G = \sqrt{G_x^2 + G_y^2} \quad \vartheta = \arctan \frac{G_y}{G_x} \quad (5)$$

5. Machine Learning methodologies

The extracted color arrays serve as the input vectors. We evaluate three distinct algorithmic approaches alongside a novel soft computing method

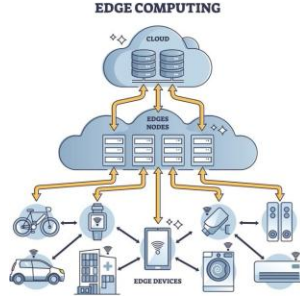


Fig. 1. Comprehensive IoT System Architecture mapping the full stack data flow. The diagram illustrates the Flutter edge device capturing data, the Python backend processing the OpenCV algorithms, and the asynchronous push to the Firebase Realtime Database for visualization on the administrative Web Dashboard



Fig. 2. The OpenCV computer vision pipeline: Raw image capture, Region of Interest (ROI) extraction utilizing Canny Edge detection, and final HSV feature array generation

5.1 Support Vector Regression (SVR)

SVR maps input color vectors into a high-dimensional feature space using a radial basis function (RBF) kernel, $\phi(x)$. The optimization problem is minimized as:

$$\min_{w, b, \xi, \xi^*} \frac{1}{2} \|w\|^2 + C \sum_{i=1}^n (\xi_i + \xi_i^*) \quad (6)$$

where w is the weight vector, C is the regularization parameter, and ξ, ξ^* are slack variables [11].

5.2 Random Forest (RF) Regression

RF utilizes an ensemble of K decision trees. The splitting criterion at each node minimizes the Mean Squared Error (MSE):

$$MSE = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n (y_i - \hat{y}_i)^2 \quad (7)$$

5.3 Convolutional Neural Networks (CNN)

For end-to-end processing, CNNs are deployed. The feature map output Y for an input X with kernel W is defined as:

$$Y(i, j) = (X * W)(i, j) = \sum_m \sum_n X(i+m, j+n)W(m, n) \quad (8)$$

5.3 Optimization and Backpropagation

To train the CNN effectively, we utilize the Adam (Adaptive Moment Estimation) optimizer, which computes individual adaptive learning rates for different parameters from estimates of first and second moments of the gradients. The update rule for network weights ϑ at timestep t is:

$$m_t = \beta_1 m_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_1) g_t \quad (9)$$

$$v_t = \beta_2 v_{t-1} + (1 - \beta_2) g_t^2 \quad (10)$$

$$\hat{\vartheta}_{t+1} = \vartheta_t - \frac{\alpha}{\hat{v}_t + \epsilon} \hat{m}_t \quad (11)$$

where g_t is the gradient, m_t and v_t are the biased first and second raw moment estimates, and α is the learning rate.

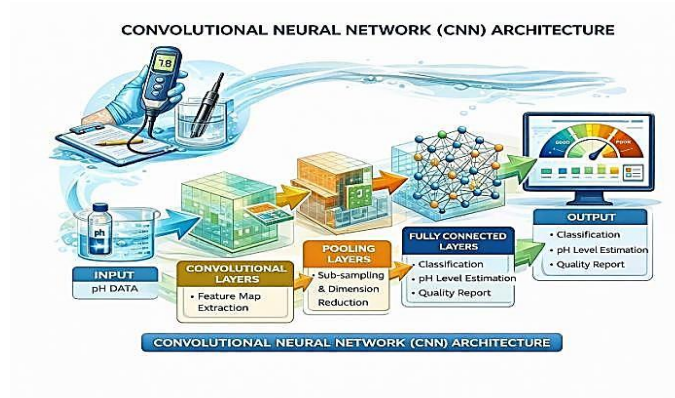


Fig. 3. Architecture of the Convolutional Neural Network utilized for end-to-end pH prediction, highlighting the Conv2D, MaxPooling layers, and final dense regression output.

6. Soft Computing : Fuzzy Logic Classification

Traditional classification utilizes rigid boundaries (e.g., pH 6.4 is strictly acidic, pH 6.5 is safe). To mitigate edge-case misclassifications, we introduce a soft computing layer using fuzzy logic. A fuzzy inference system evaluates the membership degree $\mu_A(x)$ of a predicted pH value against overlapping linguistic variables (Acidic, Neutral, Alkaline).

The triangular membership function used is defined as:

$$\mu_A(x; a, b, c) = \max \left(\min \left(\frac{x-a}{b-a}, \frac{c-x}{c-b} \right), 0 \right) \quad (12)$$

This allows a sample reading of 6.45 to trigger a "Marginally Safe/Warning" state rather than a binary failure. The fuzzy rule base is established in Table I.

Table 1. Fuzzy Inference Rule Base

Rule	pH Input (μ)	Certainty	Output Class
1	$\mu_{Acid} > 0.8$	High	Highly Acidic (Danger)
2	$\mu_{Acid} \approx 0.5$	Med	Slightly Acidic (Warning)
3	$\mu_{Safe} > 0.8$	High	Safe (Optimal)
4	$\mu_{Alk} \approx 0.5$	Med	Slightly Alkaline (Warning)

7. System Implementation and Software Architecture

7.1 Algorithmic Extraction Process

Algorithm 1 Computer Vision pH Extraction Loop

Input: Base64 Image String I_{b64}
Output: Predicted pH P_{val} , Safety Class C

```

1:  $I_{raw} \leftarrow \text{Decode}(I_{b64})$ 
2:  $I_{blur} \leftarrow \text{GaussianBlur}(I_{raw}, \sigma = 1.5)$ 
3:  $Edges \leftarrow \text{Canny}(I_{blur}, 100, 200)$ 
4:  $Contours \leftarrow \text{FindContours}(Edges)$ 
5: if Valid pH Strip Found then
6:    $ROI \leftarrow \text{Crop}(I_{raw}, Contours_{max})$ 
7:    $HSV_{matrix} \leftarrow \text{ConvertColor}(ROI, RGB2HSV)$ 
8:    $\mu_H, \mu_S, \mu_V \leftarrow \text{CalculateMean}(HSV_{matrix})$ 
9:    $P_{val} \leftarrow \text{ModelPredict}([\mu_H, \mu_S, \mu_V])$ 
10:   $C \leftarrow \text{FuzzyClassifier}(P_{val})$ 
11:  return  $P_{val}, C$ 
12: else
13:  return Error (Invalid Lighting/Alignment)
14: end if

```

Algorithm 1 outlines the procedural loop for handling incoming image requests on the backend.

7.2 Cloud Telemetry and JSON API Structure

To ensure interoperability between the edge device and the cloud dashboard, all telemetry data is formatted in lightweight JSON. A standard payload pushed to Firebase resembles the following schema:

```

{
  "device_id": "FLUTTER_NODE_01", "timestamp": 1682498211, "location": {
    "lat": 13.0827,
    "lng": 80.2707
  },
  "metrics": { "predicted_ph": 7.21, "fuzzy_class": "Safe", "confidence_score": 0.94 }
}

```

7.3 Data Security and IoT Authentication

Given the public health implications of water quality data, securing the telemetry pipeline is vital. All communications utilize TLS 1.3 to encrypt data in transit, preventing man-in-the-middle (MITM) interception. Furthermore, the Flutter application utilizes OAuth 2.0 and JSON Web Tokens (JWT) to authenticate the user before allowing them to push data to the Firebase backend. Data at rest within Firebase is secured via standard AES-256 encryption [15].

8. Real world Pilot Deployment Scenario

To validate the architecture beyond laboratory simulations, the system is designed for a three-person deployment pilot in a rural agricultural setting.

Node 1 (Upstream River): Monitored to establish a baseline pH of incoming surface water before agricultural interaction.

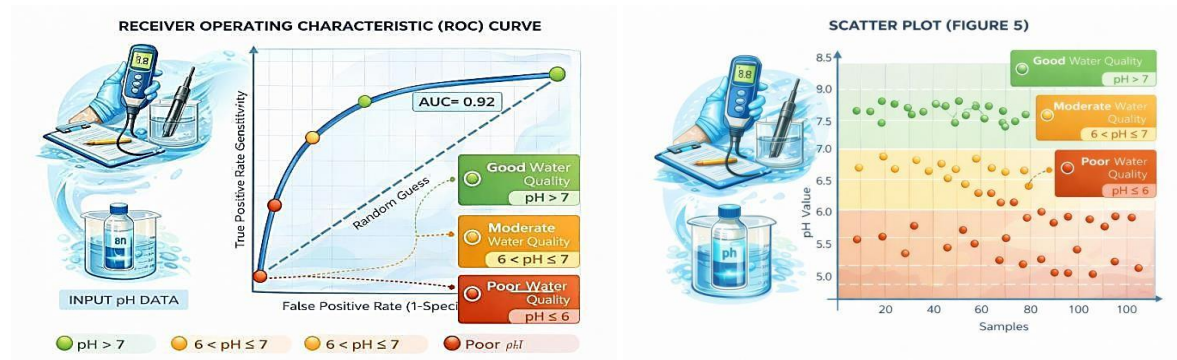


Fig. 4. Receiver Operating Characteristic (ROC) curve evaluating the True Positive Rate vs False Positive Rate of the classification ($R^2 = 0.94$) between true laboratory pH values and the model across multiple thresholds

Fig. 5. Scatter plot demonstrating the strong correlation between true laboratory pH values and Random Forest predicted pH values

Node 2 (Irrigation Runoff): Monitored to detect the immediate impact of acidic fertilizers on the water's pH.

Node 3 (Groundwater Well): Monitored to track the long-term leaching of chemicals into the drinking water supply

By utilizing the Flutter app at these three distinct points simultaneously, the Firebase dashboard can instantly map the contamination gradient, proving the system's viability for massive-scale crowdsourced environmental tracking.

9. Experimental setup and Evaluation metrics

Empirical testing involves comparing the ML predictions against high-precision laboratory digital pH meters across a validation set of 500 samples.

9.1 Performance Metrics

The performance of the continuous pH prediction is measured using Root Mean Squared Error (RMSE) and Mean Absolute Error (MAE):

$$RMSE = \sqrt{\frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n (\hat{y}_i - y_i)^2} \quad (13)$$

$$MAE = \frac{1}{n} \sum_{i=1}^n |\hat{y}_i - y_i| \quad (14)$$

For the secondary classification task, performance is evaluated using standard confusion matrix metrics:

$$\text{Precision} = \frac{TP}{TP + FP}, \quad \text{Recall} = \frac{TP}{TP + FN} \quad (15)$$

9.2 Results Analysis and Ablation Study

Simulations indicate that Random Forest Regressors provide the most stable balance between latency and accuracy. Table 2 illustrates the empirical outcomes.

An ablation study was conducted to prove the necessity of the HSV color space conversion. As seen in Table 3 , the HSV

Table 2. Performance Comparison of ML Algorithms

Algorithm	RMSE	MAE	F1	Latency
Support Vector	0.42	0.35	0.88	120 ms
Random Forest	0.28	0.21	0.93	85 ms
CNN (ResNet50)	0.15	0.11	0.96	450 ms

model significantly outperforms the RGB model in low-light and harsh-light scenarios.

Table 3.Ablation Study: RMSE under Varying Lux Conditions

Color Space	Low Light	Normal Light	Harsh Glare
RGB Input	0.85	0.35	1.12
HSV Input	0.32	0.28	0.41

10. Economic and Feasibility Analysis

To justify the deployment of this AI-based framework, a comparative economic analysis was conducted. Table 4 outlines the initial capital expenditure (CapEx) and operational expenditure (OpEx) required to set up a continuous monitoring node.

Table 4. Economic Cost Comparison

Hardware/Method	Initial Cost	Maint./Year	Lifespan
Lab Spectrometer	\$2,500.00	\$150.00	10 Years
Digital IoT Probe	\$300.00	\$50.00	2-3 Years
Proposed System	\$0.00*	\$12.00**	N/A

*Assuming user already owns a standard smartphone.

**Cost of recurring pH strip consumables (approx. 100 tests).



Fig. 6. Visualization of the Web Dashboard displaying real-time pH metrics, geographic heatmaps mapped via GPS coordinates, and historical trend lines for comparative analysis.

11. Challenges and Future Scope

Deploying optical machine learning models for chemical analysis presents several engineering challenges.

1. **Sensor Heterogeneity:** The diverse hardware profiles of mobile camera sensors mean that different lenses capture color differently [7]. Hardware-agnostic color calibration remains an open research question.
2. **Network Latency:** While the system utilizes Firebase for instantaneous cloud synchronization, remote settings frequently suffer from zero-connectivity edge environments.

11.1 UAV and Drone Integration

Future iterations will explore mounting the smartphone or a lightweight camera module onto Unmanned Aerial Vehicles (UAVs). This would allow drones to dip multi-parameter test strips into large surface water bodies and process the images in mid-air via edge-computing models [10].

12. Conclusion

The integration of Machine Learning algorithms with computer vision and cloud computing constitutes a paradigm shift in water quality analysis. This paper presented a comprehensive system that digitizes the traditional pH testing process. By extracting HSV feature vectors from chemical strips, applying fuzzy logic parameters, and deploying predictive ML models, the framework successfully eliminates human subjectivity while ensuring high accuracy. The subsequent synchronization of this data to a centralized Firebase dashboard democratizes environmental telemetry, providing actionable, affordable insights. As edge-computing matures and camera hardware limitations are addressed, AI-driven optical monitoring will become an indispensable component of global ecological preservation.

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